



SUBIR HALDER



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(LEFT) LEGENDARY FOOTBALLER KARL-HEINZ RUMMENIGGE; THE HALDIA STADIUM IS THE ONLY GROUND FOR THE IFA ACADEMY



EXPERTS BELIEVE THAT THE NEXT DECADE CAN PROVE TO BE CRUCIAL AND BENEFICIAL FOR INDIAN FOOTBALL.

Bose, says the academy's main problem is its scattered facilities. "It is not an ideal situation but more than 40 of our boys have represented their state teams and six have played for India," he says.

The Maradona experiment has left Pradip Chowdhury a tad unenthusiastic: "A couple of days spent in frenzy will not help." Given that Rs 9 crore were spent on the Maradona visitation, he says, "This kind of money could have been used to build up top-class academies for any sport in India." He calculates that, infrastructure and personnel salaries excluded, it takes about Rs 30,000 a year to run a basic residential football academy with a batch of a dozen boys. "Maradona is a legend, but will he really care about what happens to football in India?" he adds.

Other than the national academies, clubs run their own academies—JCT Mills in Punjab, Sesa in Goa and the Mohun Bagan-SAIL academy in Durgapur which has 48 trainees in three age groups. The trainees go to a local school for education. The academy, housed in a facility developed by SAIL, has a swimming pool and a well-equipped gymnasium.

An academy that had gained the admiration of the Bengal football establishment, says Pradip Chowdhury, was run by the Chandigarh Sports Department. Its single handicap though was that the academy didn't have its own team and once their training was done, the wards were on their own. "Unless they are immediately snapped

up by some club, their skills are almost wasted," he says.

Back to the pioneers then, TFA, which believes that despite the mushrooming academies, the football community's expectations from them have actually increased. The focus now is on knowledge-based training and selecting youngsters who would at least grow to be around six ft tall. "That is what national coach Bob Houghton wants," says Ranjan Chowdhury.

Ironically, there are actually very few football academies in a country as large as India with a football tradition extending back over a century. The general secretary of AIFF Alberto Colaco believes that foreign collaborations are vital for Indian football to improve. "We have to adopt new coaching methods, with proper scientific back-up. This has developed a lot overseas, and if we are to succeed we have to learn from them."

The AIFF's own inertia in the area of training/coaching is hard to explain. The ruling body has not yet been able to set up an academy of their own, planned in Colaco's home state Goa. Colaco says there were "local problems" which delayed the start of the Bharti-AIFF Football Academy. He 'hopes' that the work will begin soon.

Back to the original question. Will Maradona's or Rummenigge's few hours in India help to lift national football standards? Arguably the money spent on such visits can be used to actually make a difference on the ground but the visits of the soccer gods do much for the visibility of the sport in India. Sadly what it still needs is to get its basics in place. ■